Veneer of Stability

During the blistering summer of 1976, Honecker declared that the GDR had achieved its past objectives. Greeted by a prolonged ovation, he prattled through a 45,000-word speech at the ninth SED Party Congress, where he stated East Germany would continue its policy of détente and meet its 1975–80 goals. The special significance of the congress lay in the fact that it discussed and adopted a new programme setting the historically significant task of further building a developed socialist society and thereby creating the basic prerequisites for the gradual transition to communism.

The Party programme also mapped out the long-term outline of SED policy regarding relations with the FRG, by declaring it should be developed as relations between sovereign states with different social systems on the basis of the principles of peaceful coexistence and the norms of international law. ‘This orientation is based on the realities,’ Honecker insisted.1 In a private conversation with the US Ambassador, he spoke matter-of-factly when declaring housing for every family would be achieved by 1990, and perhaps by 1985. The congress was also interesting for unveiling plans for the promotion of television and radio in the directives for the Five-Year Plan:

The effect of radio and television is to be raised by programme improvements in order to promote more strongly the development of socialist consciousness and to satisfy better the growing demand for information, education and entertainment. Television for schools is to be expanded. Investment in radio and television is to be concentrated on the further expansion and modernisation of studios and the improvement of reception.

2